



end of the season. Against Gujarat Titans, KKR left both Rovman Powell and Matheesha Pathirana on the bench, effectively keeping open the choice between extra batting and extra bowling depending on how the innings unfolded.

When the top order fired, it opted for Pathirana. Although the ploy was undermined by injury, the thinking behind it represented genuine strategic innovation.

Not only does such a strategy increase a team's in-game flexibility, but it also allows it to reap the benefits of better squad construction. More intriguingly, it is a strategy made possible only by genuine all-rounders, the very cricketers often cited as casualties of the Impact Player era.

And to push further, could there be other creative uses of the rule? Consider a batter better equipped against spin on a turning track, a left- or right-hander suited to a skewed boundary, a left-arm spinner against

a batting order full of right-handers, or a taller seamer on a bouncy pitch.

The final provides a useful case study. Gujarat Titans opted to call on Prasidh Krishna as its Impact Player, as it has for most of the season. However, with the pitch somewhat two-paced, the evidence of Krunal Pandya's impressive spell of surprisingly conventional left-arm spin, and a host of right-handers in RCB's middle order, could GT have benefited more from having a bowler of a similar profile, such as R. Sai Kishore or Manav Suthar, to call upon?

Or, reflecting on the example of our unused substitute Raghu Sharma, MI had an entire first innings' worth of evidence suggesting seamers were far more effective, and Shardul Thakur to call upon.

Had it left Afghan mystery spinner AM Ghazanfar, who did not bat and bowled three expensive overs, on the bench, it could even have given

Calculated switch: Few teams embraced a fixed Impact Player pattern as readily as Sunrisers Hyderabad, with Travis Head and Sakib Hussain at the heart of it. ^{AP}

itself the option of bringing in a frontline bowler like Trent Boult as well.

Miles to go, but will it go?

Coming into the season, there was considerable debate about the Impact Player rule, with captains expressing reservations about it in the pre-season meeting. The BCCI has clarified that any reconsideration of the rule will only take place after the 2027 season.

However, to return to the examples of Raghu and Shardul at MI, if the Impact Player rule is scrapped in 2028, it will likely disappear before teams fully explore the strategic possibilities it offers, or, if you will, Impact the game.